What Lies Between Divergence and Convergence

A Map for Seeing Your Team's Creation Structurally

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The Unnamed Place Between Divergence and Convergence



Figure 1: The 5-Stage Model — Process Diagnosis for Designers

As a designer or PM, you have likely cycled through divergence and convergence many times. Double Diamond, sprints, iterations. Expand, then narrow. Within that rhythm, was there ever a time that was neither?

Not the expanding phase. Not the narrowing phase. Contradictory things existing simultaneously, where choosing either means losing something. Your hands stop in that discomfort.

This document starts from the hypothesis that this "unnamed place" has a structure. It does not claim correctness. It presents a map for seeing your team's creative process.

Where Are You in the Five Stages?

Divergence and convergence describe two stages. But when you look at what actually happens, five stages can be distinguished.

Field — Nothing Has Arisen

Before a project begins. Nothing exists yet. Not even "What should we build?" is visible, nor is there any sense that "something is off." Zero, void. When the first stirring — "something is on my mind" — arises from this stillness, the transition to Wave has already begun. The pitfall is being unable to endure this stillness and rushing to define scope.

Wave — Opposing Axes Emerge

Directions emerge from the unease. User needs versus technical constraints. Short-term wins versus long-term vision. Competing stakeholder expectations. Multiple axes of opposition arise simultaneously.

The divergence phase is close to this stage, but the key point at Wave is not "expanding" but "maintaining the opposition." The temptation is to settle on one direction quickly, but you carry the information within the tension forward.

Relation — Contradiction Reaches Its Peak

The oppositions born at Wave can no longer be resolved by choosing A or B. You cannot discard either A or B. Then C and D appear as well. Contradictory elements coexist, and complexity reaches its maximum.

This is the "unnamed place between divergence and convergence."

What happens to the team here: "Let's just decide" — that voice rises. The Survival-axis — deadline pressure, sprint pressure, the signal to get something tangible quickly — works most strongly at this place. If the team yields to that signal and cuts away one side to resolve the contradiction, the quality of what emerges next decreases.

Remaining at Relation means weaving relationships while holding contradictions. Not rushing to conclusions, but finding new connections between opposing elements. This is the structural meaning of "not rushing to a conclusion."

However, remaining at Relation requires a condition. The team needs a relationship where it feels safe that "not having an answer yet is okay." Without that sense of being held — psychological safety — the team may find it difficult to endure the discomfort of contradiction.

Vortex — The Prototype Emerges

From the contradictions held at Relation, a new coherence spontaneously arises. The moment when "Ah, so that's what it is" takes form. Elements that were in opposition become integrated at a higher dimension.

Something recognizable as a prototype appears, but it is not yet a settled structure. What matters at this stage is not to over-protect the form. Articulating the conditions under which the Vortex holds — where it is valid and where it breaks down — supports the transition to the next stage.

Bundle — Reusable Patterns Remain

The coherence that arose in the Vortex stabilizes as a deliverable. Reusable patterns and insights remain within the team.

The Bundle is not an endpoint. A stabilized structure becomes the starting point for the next unease. The moment you think "this direction is settled," a new "something is off" begins to drift. The return from Bundle to Field sustains creation.

If these five stages do not match your team's experience so far, that is natural. This map is one way of seeing, and your team's reality may show a different structure.

The Art of Not Fleeing at Relation

Of the five stages, the one where teams often encounter the greatest difficulty is Relation.

Contradiction is at its peak, and everyone feels the discomfort. "Let's just decide" sounds rational. But it means discarding the information contained in the opposition.

Let us look at remaining at Relation from two perspectives.

The individual perspective: When you encounter a gap between expectation and reality — that "this isn't it" feeling — instead of immediately correcting it, you hold that gap as a question. You do not rush to a conclusion. You remain in contradiction. This is called "Containment."

The team perspective: For individuals to practice Containment, the team needs a relationship that can receive it. A relationship that does not blame "not having an answer." The quality of this relationship is closely connected to how long the team can remain at Relation, which in turn plays a significant role in the quality of the Vortex.

Questions held through Containment are transformed into structure through the five stages. This is where Kesson-Driven Thinking connects.

Seeing Your Team's Creative Process

The five stages manifest in both individuals and teams with the same structure.

The "Field to Bundle" happening within an individual and the "Field to Bundle" of the team are nested. When one person is at Relation, the team as a whole might be at Wave. Or the team might be at Relation while the PM is pushing toward Bundle.

Asking "Where are we as a team in the five stages?" is how this map is used.

The hardest part is the return from Bundle to Field. Letting go of what has been made. Opening to the next unease while taking "what was decided" as a given. The difference between teams that hold and teams that do not becomes significant over time.

To Close

The last time your team said "let's just decide" — which stage was that?

If you were at Relation, that "let's just decide" may have been a retreat from the discomfort of contradiction.

These five stages are not an answer. They are one map for gaining perspective on your team's creative process. If even one current position on the map became visible, that is enough.